Richa Ghosh | 22|

Innings: 8; Runs: 235; Avg: 39.16

Being the only girl training at the Baghajatin Cricket Coaching Centre in Siliguri, West Bengal, turned out to be a blessing in disguise for Richa. Playing day after day against boys, she learned early to handle pace, bounce and the sting of hard leather. That fearlessness came to the fore at the World Cup, where the wicketkeeper-batter repeatedly rose to the occasion—whether easing pressure on Jemimah Rodrigues in the semifinal against Australia or backing up Deepti Sharma in the final. With a strike rate of 133.52, and a haul of 23 fours and 12 sixes, Richa not only powered India's big totals and audacious chases but also delighted spectators with her clean, fearless hitting. A member of the 2023 Under-19 Women's T20 World Cup–winning squad, she has since cemented her place as a key pillar of the senior side.



AP

good stead in the 2025 edition when faced with a hat trick of losses against formidable opponents. Inside the team camp, the atmosphere was "positive" even when things were not going their way, says Harmanpreet. "The coach [Amol Muzumdar] kept reminding us that we are capable of something extraordinary." This was no one-woman show; they played as a team, with every member contributing to the herculean effort.

Kranti, 22, who had come into the senior side just five months earlier, was entrusted with the responsibility of opening the bowling attack alongside Renuka Singh Thakur. Jemimah, the squad's most effervescent member, delivered a century knock of a lifetime to help India defeat seven-time world champions, Australia, in the semi-finals. "We had ups and downs, but each of us looked out for each other," Jemimah told the Sports Today channel after the win. "That's what a real champion team is all about—knowing how to pick yourself up after a fall." This was also a team unafraid to show their emotions on the field. "I am a very emotional person. I cry a lot," Harmanpreet said at one post-match press conference. "I tell my teammates, you don't need to control your emotions. Just keep enjoying."

Things had also started improving for the Indian women's cricket team three years ago, when the BCCI introduced key measures in the women's game. With Jay Shah as president, there was pay parity in match fees, access to better training facilities, a more active match calendar and, most significantly, the start of the Women's Premier League. The WPL has had three editions so far, which has led to the infusion of fresh, young blood into the national side. "The WPL has narrowed the gap between domestic and international cricket. There's financial support and recognition even if you can't make it to the national side," says Jhulan, a bowling coach with two-time WPL champions Mumbai Indians. "The quality of the game has improved because you are sharing the dressing room and playing with overseas cricketers. You see how they prepare for the game and control their nerves. There's belief that we can defeat them."



"This win should bring out a lot more girls to take up the game and for domestic cricket to improve"

— DIANA EDULJI, *veteran cricketer who was part of the original 1974 India team*

What has also helped lift the quality of the women's game is Indian cricketers getting to hone their skills in overseas leagues like the Big Bash and The Hundred. Both Harmanpreet and Smriti have made trips abroad and returned with a sharper focus on fitness. In fact, days after the World Cup win, Jemimah jetted off to Australia, becoming the only Indian cricketer to compete in the Big Bash League. "You get to